Most studies on European colonialism are typically centred around its impact on the political independence of colonised native societies, the immense economic harm caused to them and the consequent ‘illiteracy’ and impoverishment of these societies. In my opinion, this in itself is proof of coloniality since quite a few native societies are yet to understand the true impact of colonialism, namely the loss of an original indigenous perspective, which does not even seem to figure in their list of things to reclaim.

To restate, if a colonised society assesses even the loss it has suffered on account of colonialism on the anvils of ‘development’ as defined by the European coloniser, it only proves the entrenchment of coloniality. In fact, it firmly establishes the extent of internalisation of the colonial worldview deep within the native society’s consciousness, so much so that it is oblivious to the loss of its own agency over such consciousness. After all, how can one feel the loss of a thing whose existence one has become unconscious to? While it is easy to dismiss this as the elitism of the well-fed, the exhortation is not about obsessing over the loss of high culture while the masses are left to deal with soul-crushing poverty. Instead, it is about restoring something as fundamental as dignity to the native perspective so that the indigenous society can rebuild itself using its own ideals and tools instead of those of the coloniser.

Fortunately, there exists scholarship which avoids the predictable, superficial and mercantile lines of enquiry in relation to the impact of European colonialism, and delves deeper by examining the very character of economic growth which has been universalised by the European coloniser at the expense of nature. Scholars agree that apart from wiping out entire civilisations, restructuring economies and redrawing the map of the world, European colonialism’s deadliest consequence for the entire world has been its fundamental conceptual alteration of the relationship between human beings and nature.[1] In short, the introduction of ‘humanism’ and its relationship with ‘materialism’ and ‘consumerism’ can be traced to European coloniality. In stark contrast to the benevolent connotations imputed to humanism, the literature reveals, as we shall see, that it has the direct effect of placing humans over and above nature, which is the product of coloniality. This monumental shift in the approach to nature affected indigenous societies the most, since prior to European colonisation, the